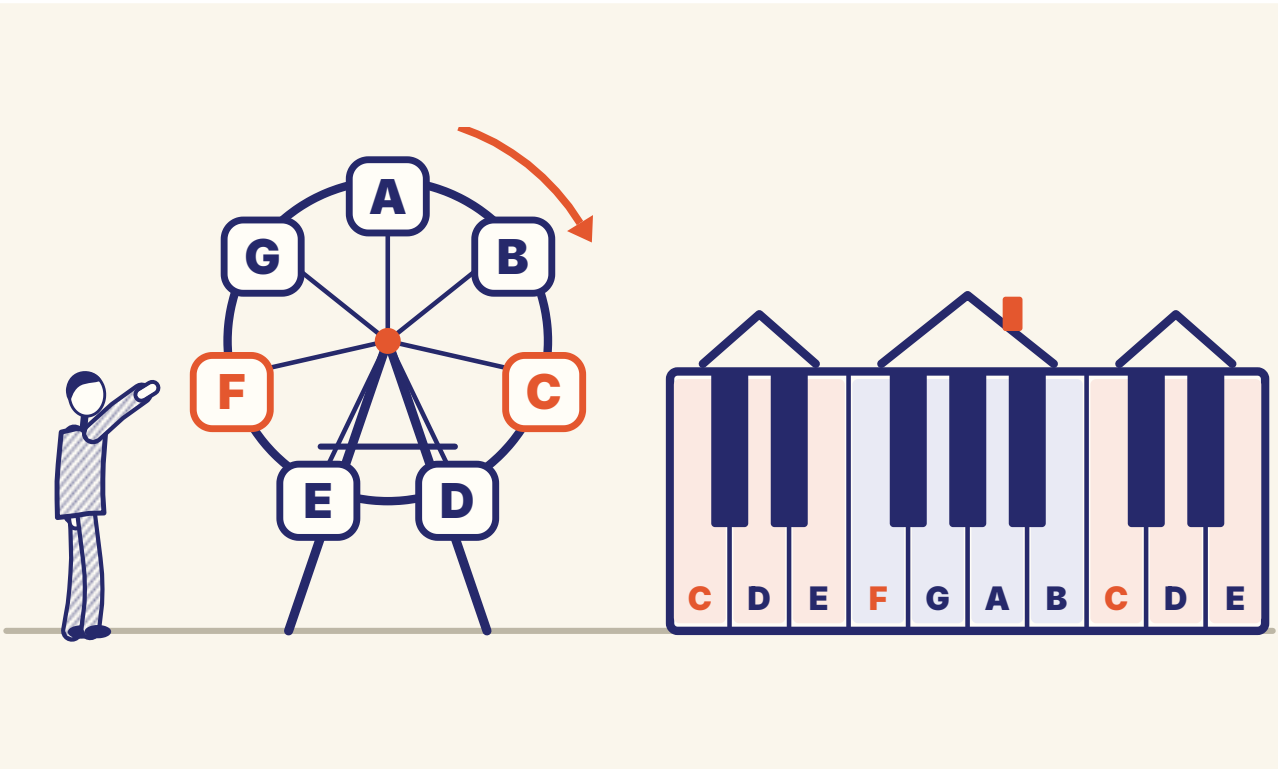
CHAPTER 3

The Musical Alphabet

Every white key has a name: a letter from A to G, the first seven letters of the alphabet. In Chapter 2 you learned the houses; now each house gets its names -- and then the names come fast: forwards and backwards, a skip at a time, all over the piano, until any key tells you its name at a glance.



In this chapter

- [ ] A to G on the keys **page 2**
- [ ] The letter wheel **page 3**
- [ ] Forwards up, backwards down **page 4**
- [ ] Name it at a glance **page 5**
- [ ] Skip a letter **page 6**
- [ ] Play by letter names **page 7**
- [ ] My five checks **page 8**

By the end, you can

- ✔ find A to G on the keys
- ✔ say the letters forwards and backwards, from any letter
- ✔ name any white key at a glance
- ✔ find the same letter in every octave
- ✔ skip up and down the keys: C E G B D F A
- ✔ play Hot Cross Buns from its letter names

ONLINE

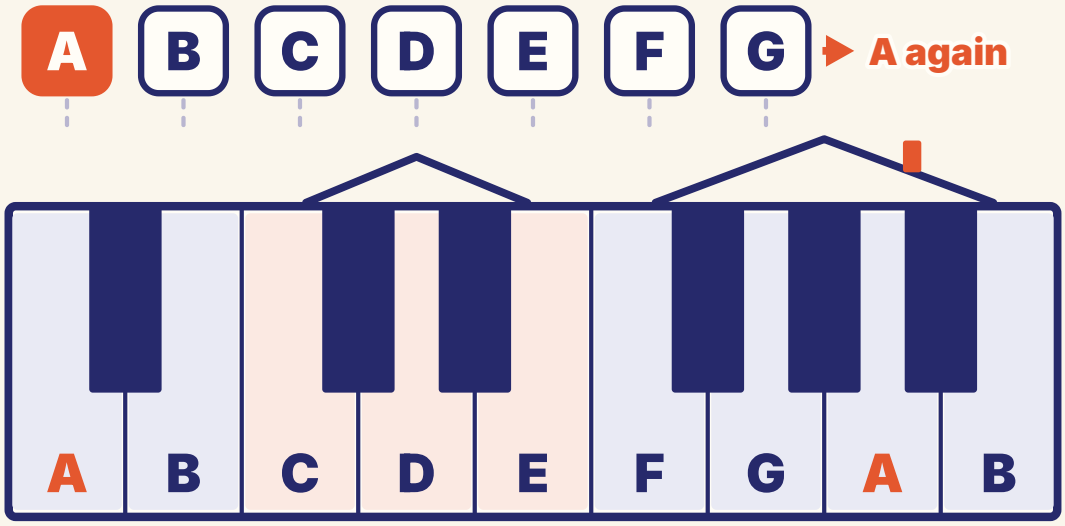
The lesson and the drill. Scan, pick a level, aim for 9 out of 10.

1. White keys · name the key __/10
2. White keys · find the key __/10
3. Two octaves · both ways __/10
4. Next letter up or down __/10
5. Skip a letter, up or down __/10

Step 1

A to G on the keys

Music uses just the **first seven letters** of the alphabet: **A B C D E F G**. The very lowest key on the piano is an **A** -- from there, the white keys go up in alphabet order: A B C D E F G, and then **A again**. The houses tell you where each one lives: **C D E** in the small house, **F G A B** in the big one, with **C** and **F** at the left doors. (In Do Re Mi, C is Do, D is Re, E is Mi...)



C D E: the small house · F G A B: the big house

At the piano

1. Find the **lowest key** on the piano: it is A. Walk up the white keys saying A B C D E F G -- and A again. ☐
2. Find and play every **C** (the small house's left door) and every **F** (the big house's left door). ☐
3. Someone says a letter; use the houses to find it -- then play it in three different places. ☐

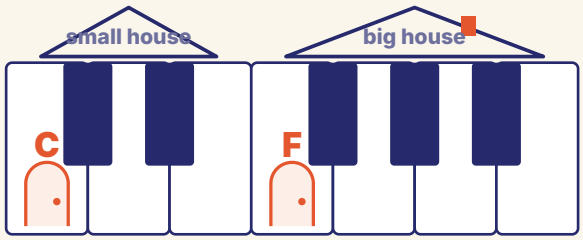
REMEMBER **A B C D E F G: C D E in the small house, F G A B in the big.**

Lesson step 1

online

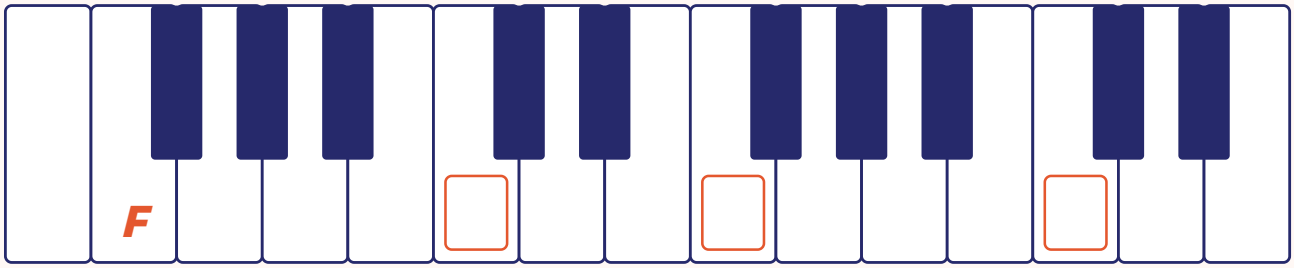
TRY IT Find every C and F

Write C or F in every box.



C is the small house's left door. F is the big house's left door.

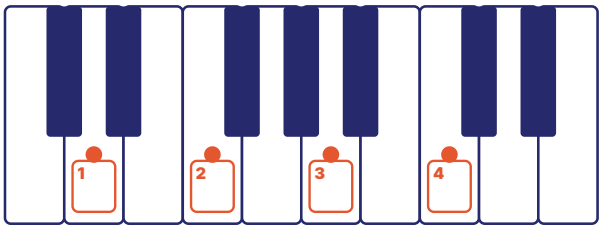
EXAMPLE



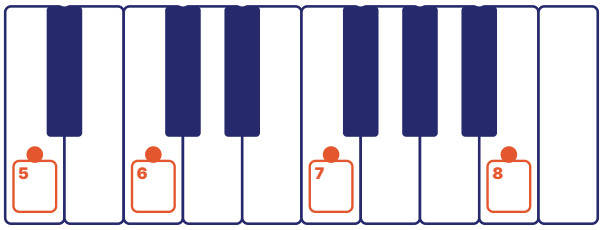
YOUR TURN Name the dotted keys

Find the house, then its left door, and walk along from there. Write the letter in the box.

1-4

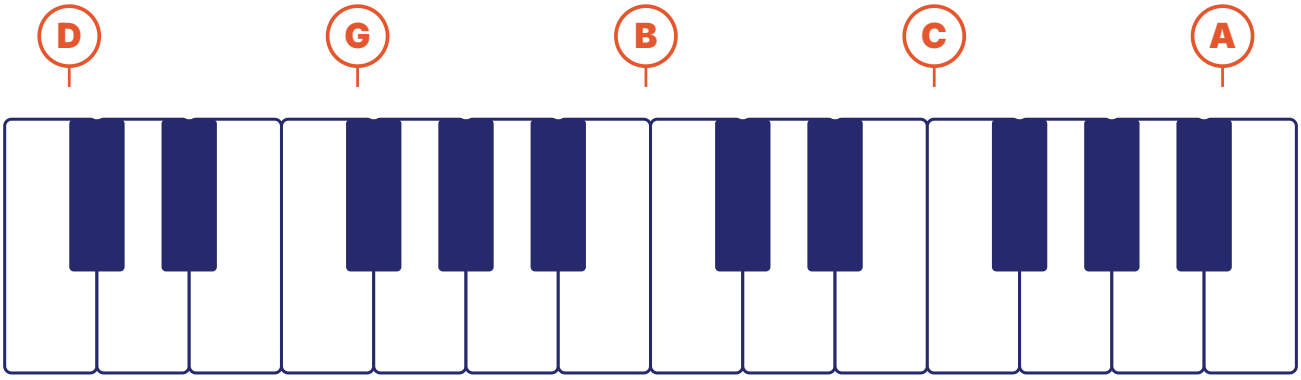


5-8



★ PLAY Lost letters

Five letters have floated away from their keys! Draw a line from each balloon down to the key it lives on. Then draw a roof on every house.



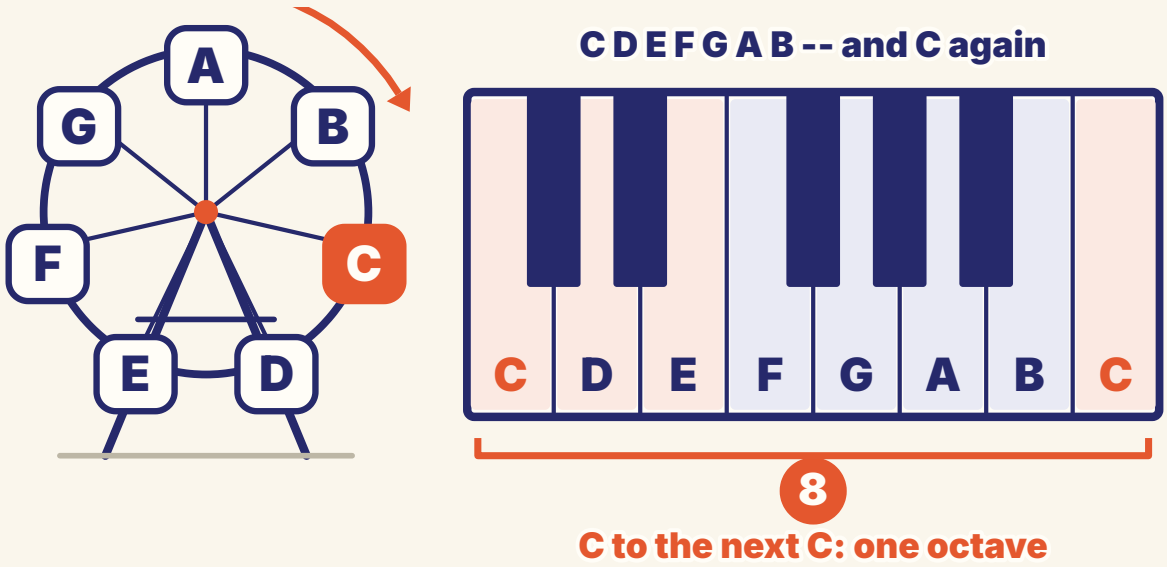
How did it feel? Circle one.

Checked ☐

Step 2

The letter wheel

Music uses only **seven letters**: A B C D E F G. After G, the wheel comes round to **A** again -- round and round like the days of the week; there is no H. Each time round, the same letter comes back. From one C up to the next C is called an **octave** -- *oct* means eight, like the eight legs of an octopus: 8 white keys, counting both Cs. Same name, higher voice.



At the piano

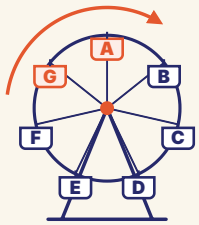
1. Start on the lowest **A** and play every white key to the top, saying the letters: A B C D E F G, A B C... ☐
2. Play **middle C**, then walk up 8 white keys to the next C, saying the letters -- one octave: the wheel has gone round once. ☐
3. Someone says any letter; you carry on round the wheel: "E" -- "F G A B C..." ☐

REMEMBER **Seven letters, round and round: after G comes A.**

Lesson step 2 online

TRY IT Fill in the missing letters

Say the letters round the wheel out loud, then fill the gaps.



Music has only 7 letters, A to G, going round like a Ferris wheel. After G, you are back at A.

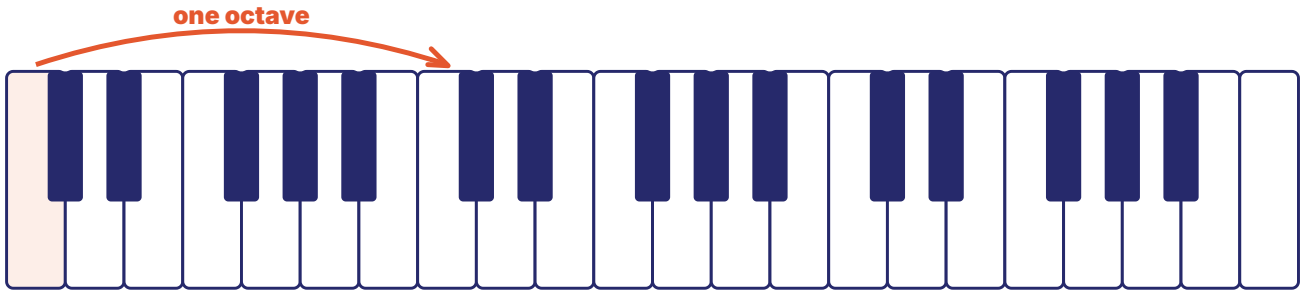
EXAMPLE	F	G	A	*B*	*C*	D	E	*F*
2	E			A	B		D	E
3	E	F		A	B		D	

YOUR TURN Fill them in on your own

1	G		B	C		E	
2	A	B	C			F	
3	G				D	E	F
4	A		C	D		F	
5	D			G		B	C
6	E			A	B		D

★ PLAY Same letter, every octave

Colour every C. Then draw a hop from each C to the next C, like the first one. Each hop is one octave: 8 white keys, counting both Cs.



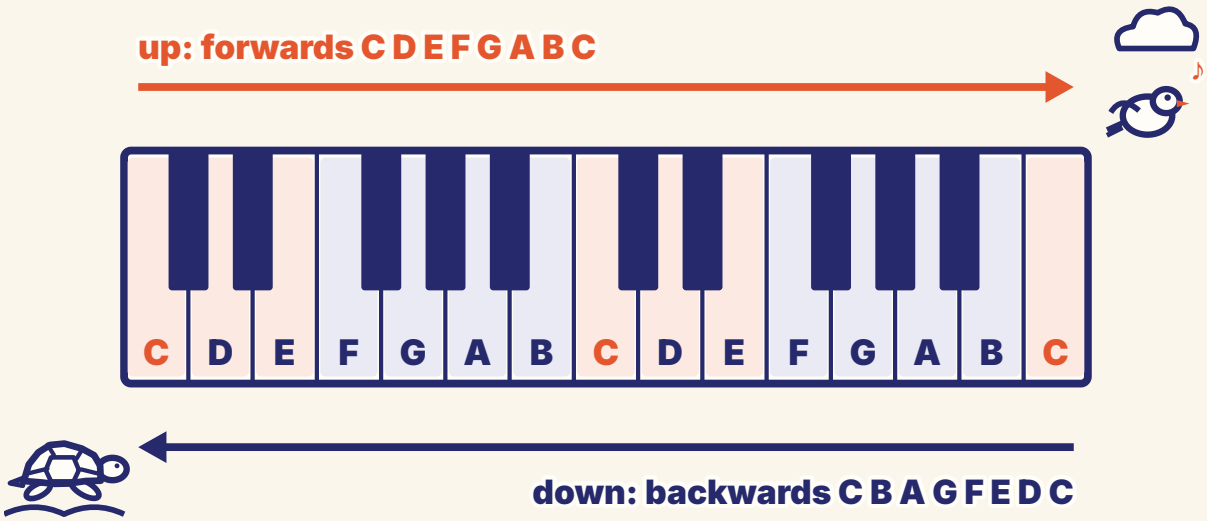
Cs on this keyboard: ☐ Octave hops: ☐

How did it feel? Circle one. ☺ 😐 ☹ Checked ☐

Step 3

Forwards up, backwards down

Going **up** the piano -- to the right, towards the bird in the sky -- the letters go **forwards**: C D E F G A B C. Going **down** -- to the left, towards the turtle under the sea -- the wheel turns the other way, and the letters go **backwards**: C B A G F E D C. Backwards is the tricky one: say it until it comes as quickly as forwards -- on the keys, and in your head.



At the piano

1. From **middle C**, play up one white key at a time to the next C, saying the letters forwards. ☐
2. Come back down to middle C, saying them backwards: **C B A G F E D C**. ☐
3. Start on **G** and go down to the G below. Careful where the wheel turns back from A to G! ☐

Away from the piano

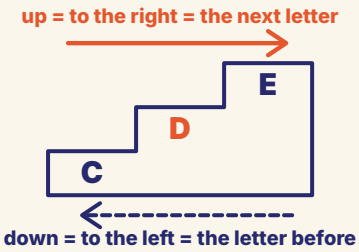
1. No piano, no keys: say the letters **backwards in your head** -- G F E D C B A -- then start from E, from B, from any letter. ☐
2. In the car, in the bath, on the way to school -- until backwards comes as fast as forwards. ☐

REMEMBER **Up the piano: forwards. Down the piano: backwards.**

Lesson step 3 online

TRY IT One step up, one step down

Write the letter one step up (the next letter) or one step down (the letter before).



Up a step = one key to the RIGHT = the next letter. Down a step = one key to the LEFT = the letter before.

EXAMPLE	2	3	4
D → one up *E*	F ← one down ☐	A → one up ☐	G ← one down ☐

YOUR TURN Backwards

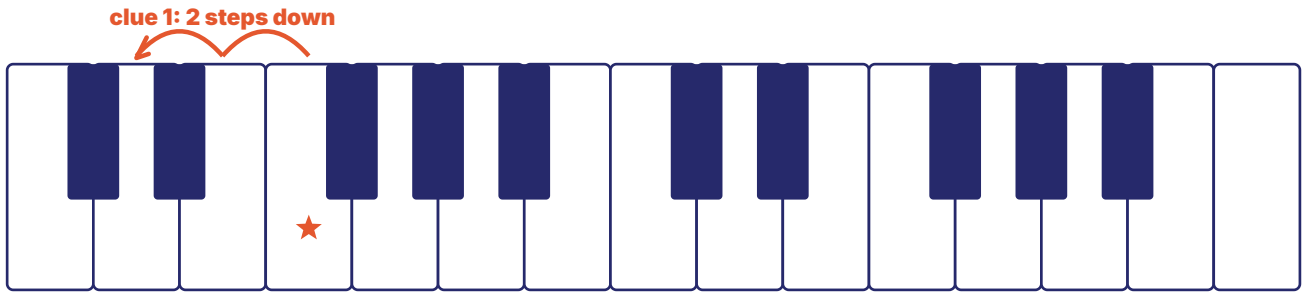
Each row goes backwards, down the piano. Watch out for A -- the letter before A is G.

1	C	B	☐	G	F	☐	☐
2	C	B	☐	☐	F	☐	D
3	B	☐	G	F	☐	D	☐
4	G	☐	E	D	☐	☐	A

In my head, no piano: the letters backwards, from a different letter each day. Tick a day: Mon ☐ Tue ☐ Wed ☐ Thu ☐ Fri ☐ Sat ☐ Sun ☐

★ PLAY Treasure hunt

Start on the star (F). One step = the next white key. Follow each clue, write the letter you land on, and start the next clue from there. Clue 1 is done: the arrow shows the hop. Draw a treasure chest on the last key!



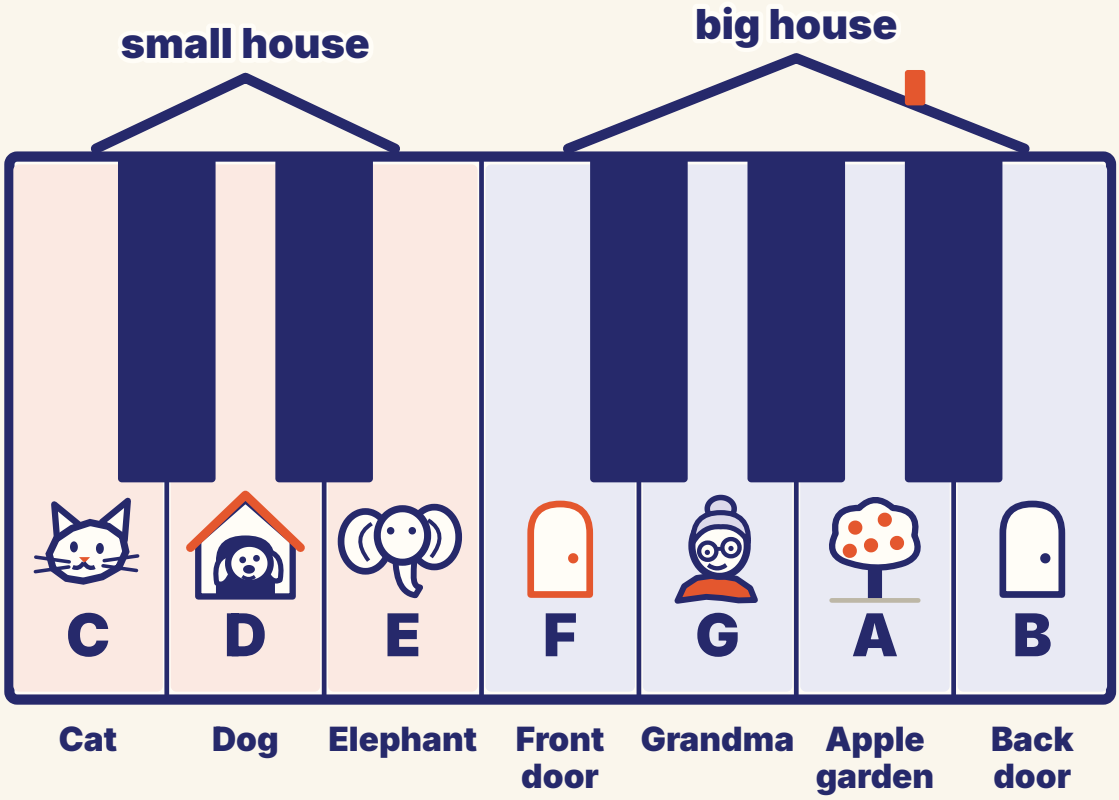
CLUE 1 · EXAMPLE	CLUE 2	CLUE 3	CLUE 4	CLUE 5	CLUE 6
2 steps down *D*	2 steps up ☐	2 steps up ☐	1 step down ☐	4 steps up ☐	3 steps up ☐

How did it feel? Circle one. ☺ 😐 ☹ Checked ☐

Step 4

Name it at a glance

Walking up from C every time is slow. Instead, look at **who lives there**. In the small house, the **Dog** lives in the middle, in his doghouse between the two black keys: that is **D**. The **Cat** sits at the left door (**C**) and the **Elephant** at the right door (**E**). The big house has a **Front door** (**F**) and a **Back door** (**B**); inside lives **Grandma** (**G**), who loves apples -- so right next to her is her **Apple garden** (**A**).



At the piano

1. Find **every D** on the piano: the Dog in his doghouse, between the two black keys. ☐
2. Find **every G and A**: Grandma and her Apple garden, inside the big house. ☐
3. **Fast game:** someone touches any white key; say who lives there and its letter -- "Elephant: E!" Then swap. ☐

REMEMBER **Don't count from C: ask who lives there.**

Lesson step 4 online

TRY IT Who lives where?

Put a dot on the key where each one lives. The first one is done.

EXAMPLE



Dog



2



Elephant



3



Back door



4



Grandma



YOUR TURN Name it at a glance

First the last three: a dot on their keys. Then write the letter of each dotted key below -- don't count from C, think who lives there.

4



Front door



5



Cat



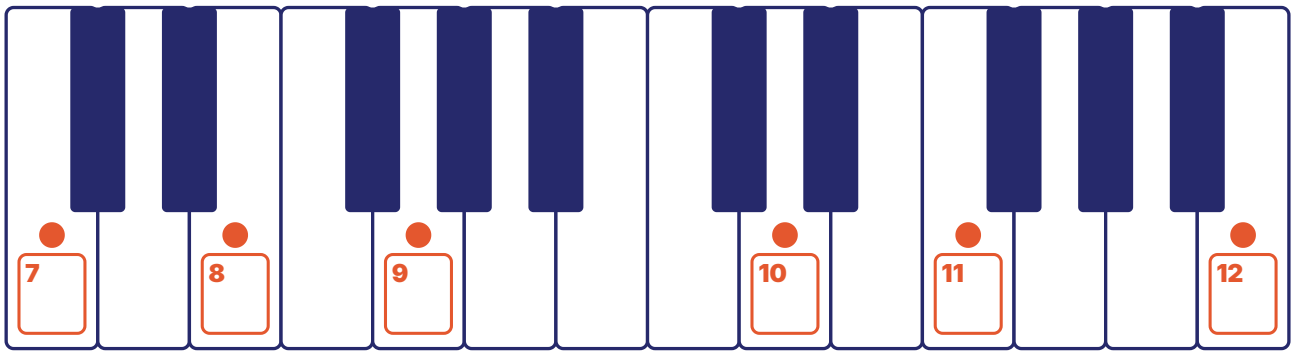
6



Apple garden

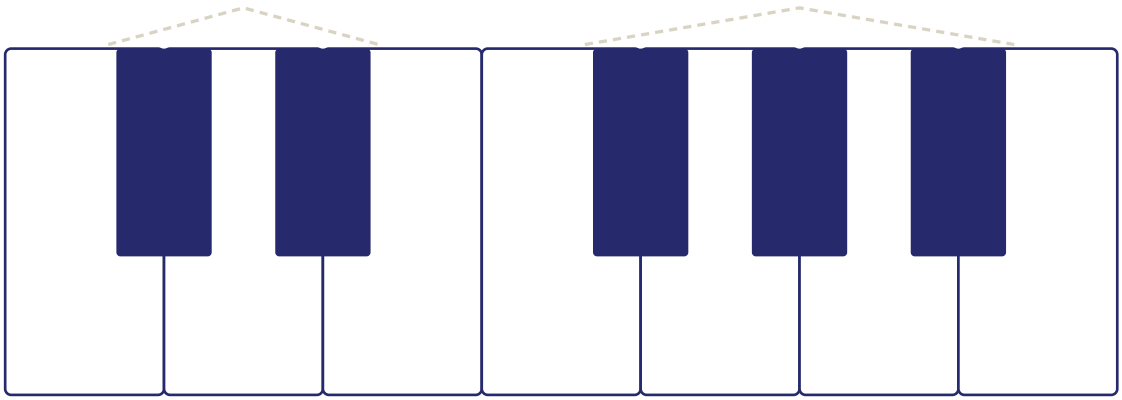


7-12



★ PLAY Draw who lives here

Draw them on their keys: the Cat, the Dog in his doghouse and the Elephant in the small house; the Front door, Grandma, her Apple garden and the Back door in the big house.

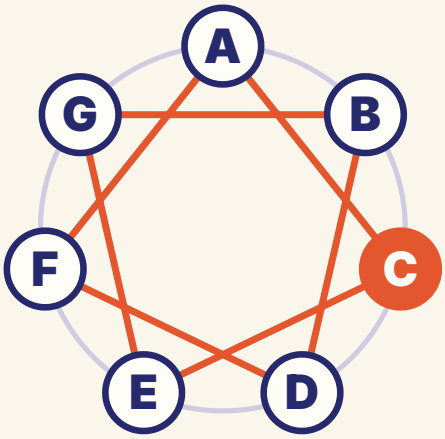


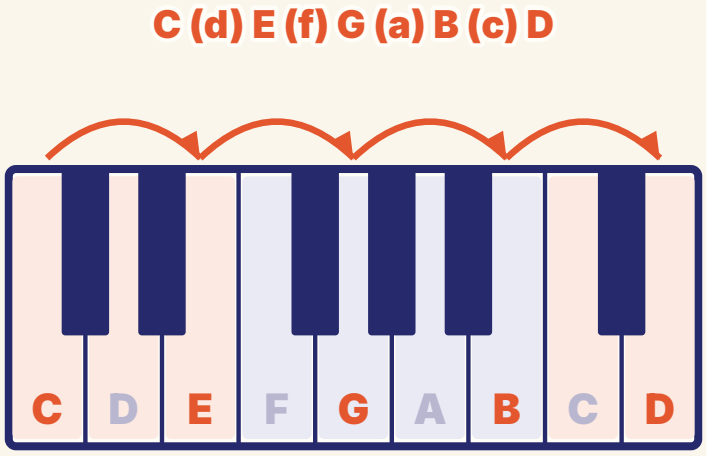
How did it feel? Circle one. Checked

Step 5

Skip a letter

A **step** goes to the very next letter. A **skip** jumps over one: C, (D), **E**, (F), **G**... Skip all the way round the wheel -- C E G B D F A, and back to C -- and the lines draw a **star**. On the piano, a skip jumps over one white key. At first, **whisper** the letter you jump over -- C (d) E (f) G -- then leave the whisper out.





a skip jumps over one white key

At the piano

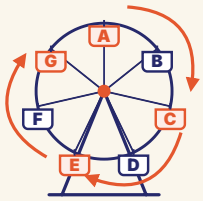
1. With finger 3, skip up from middle C: **C E G B D F A C**. Whisper the letters in between at first; then say only the ones you play. ☐
2. Skip back down: **C A F D B G E C**. ☐
3. Someone says a letter; you say the letter a skip up (C → E, F → A, A → C). ☐

REMEMBER **A skip jumps over a friend: C, (D), E.**

Lesson step 5 online

TRY IT Skip a letter

Say each row out loud first -- whisper the letter you jump over -- then fill the gaps.



Skipping: hop over one gondola each time. A (b) C (d) E... *(whisper the letter you jump over)*

EXAMPLE	B	D	F	A	*C*	*E*	*G*	B
2	F	A			G		D	F
3	B	D			C	E	G	

YOUR TURN Your turn

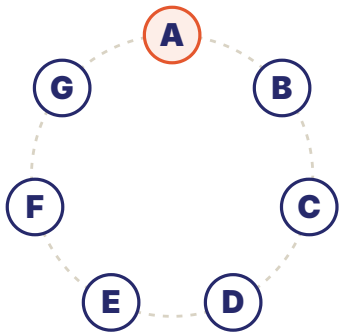
Rows 1-2 skip up. Rows 3-4 skip down (C, A, F...).

1	E	G		D			C
2	B				C	E	G

3	A				G	E	C
4	D	B		E	C		

★ PLAY Draw the letter star

Start on A. Skip a letter each time (A, C, E...) and join them with a ruler as you go. Keep going until you are back on A -- what shape did you make?



Write the letters you visit:

A							A

My shape is a _____

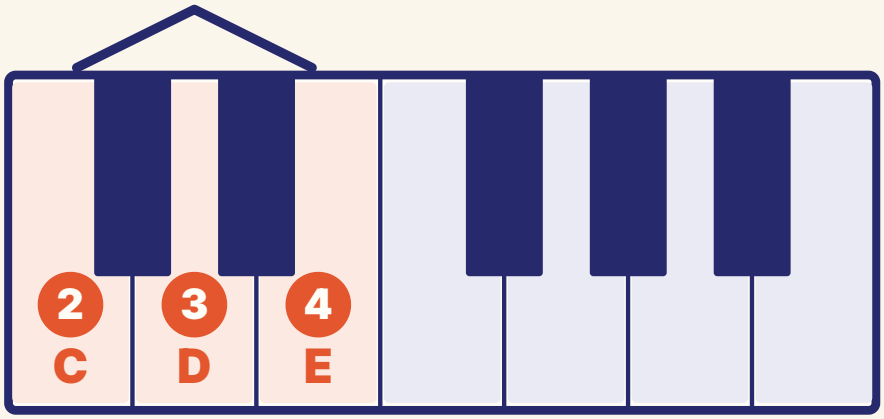
Musicians use this skip all the time: C E G is a chord!

How did it feel? Circle one. ☺ 😐 ☹ Checked ☐

Play

Play by letter names

Last chapter, Hot Cross Buns lived on the big black roof. Now it moves into the **small house**: right-hand **2 3 4** on **C D E**, and this time you read the **letters**, not the finger numbers. Then try the left hand, one small house lower.



Hot Cross Buns right hand 2 3 4 on C D E; read the letters; one circle = one steady beat

E D C | E D C | C C C C D D D D | E D C

Spell and play — a word made only of music letters is a tiny tune. Play **BAG**, **CAFE**, **FACE**, **BEAD**, **EGG**, saying each letter as you play it -- then make up a word of your own.

At the piano

1. Right-hand **2, 3, 4** on **C D E** near middle C. Sing the letters as you play: **E D C...** ☐
2. Left hand: **4, 3, 2** on C D E one small house lower -- the same letters, a lower voice. ☐
3. **Letter chain:** you say a letter, someone says the next -- faster and faster, then backwards! ☐

REMEMBER **Read the letter, see its place, play -- no counting from C.**

Lesson step 6

online

TRY IT Hot Cross Buns in letters

Fill in the missing letters, then play it: right hand 2 3 4 on C D E, reading the letters.

E D C ___ | E D ___ ___ | C C ___ C D ___ D D | ___ D ___ ___

YOUR TURN This week

Tick each one you do.

	Mon	Tue	Wed	Thu	Fri	Sat	Sun
Hot Cross Buns, right hand, reading the letters	☐	☐	☐	☐	☐	☐	☐
Hot Cross Buns, left hand, one small house lower	☐	☐	☐	☐	☐	☐	☐
Letter chain with someone: forwards	☐	☐	☐	☐	☐	☐	☐
Letter chain: backwards	☐	☐	☐	☐	☐	☐	☐
Spell and play: BAG, CAFE, FACE	☐	☐	☐	☐	☐	☐	☐

★ PLAY Music word search

These words use only music letters. Find each one -- across or down -- ring it, tick it, and play it on the piano!

B	B	C	G	F	G	E	E	B
E	D	A	G	C	F	G	F	F
A	C	B	C	A	A	G	B	F
D	C	C	D	E	G	G	A	B
D	B	A	C	D	D	G	D	F
F	C	F	B	D	C	D	G	C
A	A	E	A	F	A	C	E	A
B	G	B	G	F	C	B	D	C
F	E	D	E	A	B	A	D	F

- ☐ BAG
- ☐ CAFE
- ☐ EGG
- ☐ FACE
- ☐ BADGE
- ☐ CAGE
- ☐ BEAD

Bonus: make up your own music word

_____

How did it feel? Circle one. ☺ 😐 ☹ Checked ☐

Check-up

My five checks

At the piano: show each one, then tick how it is going -- not yet, nearly, or got it! On paper: do the check-up below.

At the piano

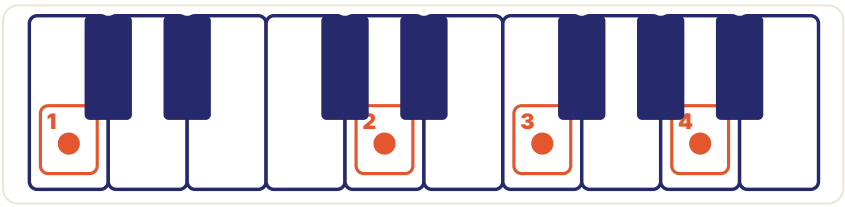
		Not yet	Nearly	Got it!
A B C D E F G	I can find A to G on the keys (C and F at the left doors)	○	◑	☆
C D E → ← C B A	I can say the letters forwards and backwards, from any letter	○	◑	☆
D	I can name any white key at a glance: who lives there?	○	◑	☆
C E G	I can skip up and down: C E G B D F A	○	◑	☆
E D C	I can play Hot Cross Buns from its letters, legato	○	◑	☆

Tick a box each time it gets better: not yet, then nearly, then got it!

On paper

Name _____ Date _____ · no help, no piano · about 10 minutes

A Name the dotted keys.



B Fill in the missing letters.

5-6 E F ☐ A ☐ C D

7-8 A B ☐ D ☐ F G

C One step up or down.

9 G → one up ☐

10 D ← one down ☐

11 A ← one down ☐

12 E → one up ☐

D Row 1 goes backwards. Row 2 skips a letter.

13-14 F E ☐ C B A ☐

15-16 F A ☐ ☐ G B D

E Hot Cross Buns: write the letters under the beats.

E D 17 ☐ ◌ | E 18 ☐ C ◌

Teacher copy · The Musical Alphabet

Each workbook page faces its Lesson Book page. Chapter 2 gave the keyboard its pattern; this chapter gives every white key its name, A to G, and makes the names fast -- forwards, backwards (on the keys and in the head), at a glance, and a skip at a time. Black keys keep no names yet (sharps and flats come with Tones & Semitones); interval numbers wait for Intervals. TRY IT comes first (its first item is the worked example), then YOUR TURN and PLAY.

p. 2 A to G on the keys

TRY IT 1. **F C F C (left to right)**

YOUR TURN 1. **D** 2. **F** 3. **A** 4. **C** 5. **A** 6. **C** 7. **F** 8. **B**

PLAY Each balloon joins any key with that letter (D: 2nd or 9th white key, G: 5th or 12th, B: 7th or 14th, C: 1st or 8th, A: 6th or 13th); roofs over every 2-group and 3-group

Watch for

Crossing into F G A at the three-black-key roof -- the most common stumble. Finding C by counting from the bottom of the piano instead of using the houses.

If stuck, try saying

"C and F are the left doors: C of the small house, F of the big one."

p. 3 The letter wheel

TRY IT 1. **B C F** 2. **F G C** 3. **G C E**

YOUR TURN 1. **A D F** 2. **D E G** 3. **A B C** 4. **B E G** 5. **E F A** 6. **F G C**

PLAY 1. **4 Cs (the 1st, 8th, 15th and 22nd white keys)** 2. **3 octave hops**

Watch for

Carrying on past G to H. Starting every row from A in their head instead of from the letter given.

If stuck, try saying

"Seven letters, round and round: after G comes A -- like Sunday back to Monday."

p. 4 Forwards up, backwards down

TRY IT 1. **E** 2. **E** 3. **B** 4. **F**

YOUR TURN 1. **A E D** 2. **A G E** 3. **A E C** 4. **F C B**

PLAY 1. **D** 2. **F** 3. **A** 4. **G** 5. **D** 6. **G**

Watch for

Backwards is much slower than forwards -- that is normal. Saying it backwards in the head, without the keyboard, matters as much as on the keys: a little every day, away from the piano. Up is to the right, and the sound goes higher.

If stuck, try saying

"Up the piano: forwards. Down the piano: backwards. Before A comes G."

p. 5 Name it at a glance

TRY IT 1. **D (Dog)** 2. **E (Elephant)** 3. **B (Back door)** 4. **G (Grandma)**

YOUR TURN 1. **F (Front door)** 2. **C (Cat)** 3. **A (Apple garden)** 4. **C** 5. **E** 6. **G** 7. **D** 8. **F** 9. **B**

PLAY C the Cat, D the Dog in his doghouse, E the Elephant; F the Front door, G Grandma, A her Apple garden, B the Back door

Watch for

Counting up from C to find every key. Ask "Who lives there?" instead. Each one sits in its key's place: the Dog between the two black keys, Grandma and the Apple garden between the three.

If stuck, try saying

"Cat, Dog, Elephant -- Front door, Grandma, Apple garden, Back door."

p. 6 Skip a letter

TRY IT 1. **C E G** 2. **C E B** 3. **F A B**

YOUR TURN 1. **B F A** 2. **D F A** 3. **F D B** 4. **G A F**

PLAY 1. **A C E G B D F A -- a 7-point star**

Watch for

Skips are the hardest part of this chapter for most children. Landing on the very next letter instead of jumping one. Start slowly with the whispered letter, then drop it.

If stuck, try saying

"Whisper the one you jump over: C (d) E (f) G."

p. 7 Play by letter names

TRY IT 1. **D** 2. **C** 3. **C** 4. **D** 5. **E** 6. **C**

PLAY 1. **BAG down from row 6 col 4** 2. **CAFE down from row 4 col 3** 3. **EGG down from row 1 col 7** 4. **FACE across from row 7 col 5** 5. **BADGE down from row 3 col 8** 6. **CAGE down from row 6 col 2** 7. **BEAD down from row 1 col 1**

Watch for

Reading the finger numbers instead of the letters: have them sing the letter names while they play. Fingers 2 3 4 only; 1 and 5 wait for C position. The legato is still the relay baton.

If stuck, try saying

"Read the letter, see its place, play."

p. 8 My five checks · the check-up on paper

A 1. **G** 2. **D** 3. **F** 4. **A**

B 1. **G B** 2. **C E**

C 1. **A** 2. **C** 3. **G** 4. **F**

D 1. **D G** 2. **C E**

E 1. **C** 2. **D**

Chapter 1's five checks still come first at the piano. This chapter's five checks are shown on the keyboard or said out loud (A to G on the keys, forwards and backwards, at a glance, skips, Hot Cross Buns by letters); you only correct. The paper part follows the same order: score each part on its own (A, B, C, D: 4 marks, pass 3+; E: 2 marks). Not passed? Go back to that step's page: A p.2 and p.5 · B p.3 · C p.4 · D p.4 and p.6 · E p.7.